

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

V FOR... PM Modi with Meerut BJP candidate Arun Govil, Apna Dal (S) chief Anupriya Patel, Haryana CM Nayab S. Saini, Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath, RLD chief Jayant Chaudhary and others at a rally in Meerut, Mar. 31

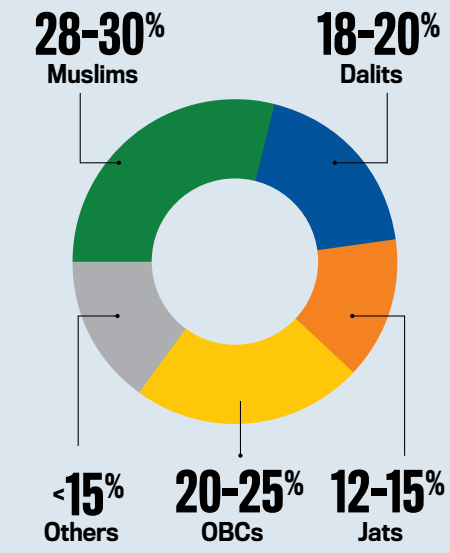
community makes up close to 16 per cent of the population, and are the RLD's core voters. But Dalits (18-20 per cent) and Muslims (28-30 per cent) play an equally key role in poll outcomes in the state's 'sugar belt'. Both the ruling National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) have opted for candidate profiles corresponding to these affiliations. However, the entry of Mayawati's Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) as a standalone third pole in the contest could queer the pitch for both the main alliances in specific seats, say analysts.

The BJP had bagged 10 of these seats—Muzaffarnagar, Pilibhit, Kairana, Meerut, Baghpat, Ghaziabad, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Bulandshahr, Aligarh and Mathura—in 2019, defeating the Samajwadi Party (SP)-BSP-RLD alliance candidates in their strongholds. This time, the RLD is with the NDA and has been allotted the Jat heartland seats of Baghpat and Bijnor. Prime Minister Narendra Modi kicked off a long, seven-phase campaign season in UP from Meerut on March 31, addressing a public rally with Jayant. Underlining the region's electoral salience, western UP continued to figure prominently in the PM's pressing poll schedule—a rally in Saharanpur on April 5 was followed by a road show in Ghaziabad a week later.

Besides trying to consolidate the Muslim vote (which can go up to 42 per cent in constituencies such as Kairana), INDIA partners SP and Congress have been trying to woo the Dalits by giving them tickets even in non-reserved seats like Meerut and Faizabad. But the SP is having trouble uniting its cadre after the high-voltage drama that unfolded on the last day of nominations—candidates for the Meerut, Baghpat,

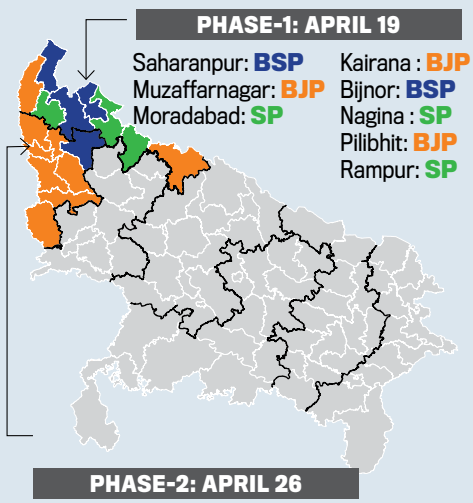
BLOC BY BLOC

Population break-up in western UP



A SAFFRON BASTION

How the 16 constituencies in the first two phases voted in 2019



PHASE-2: APRIL 26

Gautam Buddha Nagar: BJP
Ghaziabad: BJP
Meerut: BJP
Baghpat: BJP
Amroha : BSP
Aligarh : BJP
Bulandshahr: BJP
Mathura: BJP